The Modi–Rajat bond would survive the test of time. ‘Modi would come to our house for simple vegetarian food when he was in Delhi in the 1990s. I guess we hit it off well right from the beginning,’ reminisces Rajat. When Modi was sworn in as Gujarat chief minister in December 2002 after the riots, he invited Rajat to be his special guest. ‘I was reluctant as a journalist to be seen on stage with Modi, but he was insistent. He said that I was being invited as a friend, not as a journalist,’ he told me.

Rajat was fondly referred to as ‘Panditji’ by Modi. So when he approached Modi for an interview soon after he became the BJP’s prime ministerial candidate in September 2013, the response was positive. ‘I will do it, I promise, Panditji, but let us wait for the right time,’ he’d told Rajat.

The ‘right time’ was originally meant to be just before the election campaign really took off in March. But caught in the whirl of ticket distribution and rallies across the country, Modi kept delaying the interview. Finally, 12 April 2014 was fixed as the date. It was perfect timing. The first two rounds of the voting were just over, and the election was about to enter the critical phases across much of north India. *Aap ki Adalat* was the ideal platform. It was Hindi news TV’s longest running show, with a loyal viewership. And the host was someone with whom Modi had a high degree of comfort.

The interview almost didn’t happen on the day. Modi had been relentlessly campaigning that day across Bihar and Bengal, and had addressed half a dozen rallies. He had promised Rajat he would fly down to Delhi after the rallies were over and drive straight to the India TV studios, at least a ninety-minute drive from the airport. When Modi finally arrived, it was 10.45 p.m. and he was totally exhausted. His throat was hurting and he was struggling to speak. ‘We told him to rest a bit, hoping that he would feel better. We even offered him some food but he said he was observing Navaratra so would only drink water,’ recalls Rajat. For the next hour, Modi rested with a flask of warm water by his side. ‘*Panditji, programme karte hain, lekin fifteen to twenty minutes ke liye, usse zyada karna muskhil hoga’* (I will do the programme, but only for fifteen to twenty minutes—more than that will be tough), a tired Modi told Rajat.